Conjeevaram Natarajan Annadurai was born in the town of Kanchipuram in Madras State (present-day Tamil Nadu). Although their traditional caste occupation was weaving, Annadurai's family encouraged him to go to school, and to later pursue economics at Pachaiyappa's College in Madras. Annadurai became a voracious reader and a persuasive public speaker and writer. These talents and an interest in social reform led him to seek a career in public service. He found himself drawn to the Justice Party, which was active in local politics at the time.

Brahmins (on account of their high caste status) were generally more privileged, had better access to education and thus got most of the better-paying jobs during the colonial period. The Justice Party, which saw the Congress as Brahmin-dominated, was founded to demand better jobs and educational opportunities for non-Brahmins.



Erode Venkatappa Ramasamy, better known as 'EVR' or 'Periyar', was Annadurai's political mentor. In 1925, he began the Self-Respect Movement to encourage rational thinking and the rejection of